Rav Mordechai Eliyahu: a light that lasts

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נר מצוה ותורה אור

A mitzvah is a lamp, and Torah is light.

Mishlei 6:23 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Rav Shmuel Eliyahu relates that he met a woman at Me'arat HaMachpelah who told him about attending Chanukah lighting with his father, Rav Mordechai Eliyahu. The experience moved her to want a home filled with Torah and joy. She began attending Torah classes and became more careful with berachot and tefillah. Years later, she still remembered that lighting as a turning point. This is an abridged retelling of her recollection, published in Avihem Shel Yisrael, volume 11, and on the Rav's memorial website. Its message for us: an inspiring moment can lead to a lasting practice.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

The shamash does not count toward the night's mitzvah lights. Tonight there are seven mitzvah lights plus the shamash. Keep it visibly separate, following your family's Chanukiah arrangement.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Each person chooses one small practice to continue after Chanukah: a berachah said thoughtfully, a short Torah conversation, or a regular act of kindness. Tell your partner when you will do it. Partners help each other choose something realistic.

Younger learners: Which good practice would you like to do again tomorrow?
Older learners: Which details in the account show a change in actions, rather than only a strong feeling?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Whose Chanukah lighting did the woman attend? 2. Name one practice she strengthened afterward.

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Read Mishlei 6:23 and the story again. Which image in the verse helps explain the story? Label your connection as an interpretation, not something the woman or Rav explicitly said.

Sources: Mishlei 6:23; Story: Avihem Shel Yisrael, vol. 11; account related by Rav Shmuel Eliyahu; Separate shamash: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 673:1.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Mishlei 6:23 | A lamp and a light

Complete verse, without cantillation or vowel marks

כי נר מצוה ותורה אור ודרך חיים תוכחות מוסר.

For a mitzvah is a lamp, and Torah is light; corrective instruction is the way of life.

2. Rashi on Mishlei 6:23 | Torah that stays with us

Opening explanation

כמו שהאור מאיר לעולם תמיד כך התורה עומדת זכותה לעולם אל האדם וזכות מצוה לפי שעה כאור הנר

Just as light continually illuminates the world, the merit of Torah remains with a person forever; the merit of a mitzvah is for its moment, like the light of a lamp.

3. Avihem Shel Yisrael, vol. 11 | Published story excerpt

Brief verbatim excerpt from the account related by Rav Shmuel Eliyahu; the front contains an abridged retelling

היא התחילה לשמוע שיעורי תורה

She began attending Torah classes.

4. Shulchan Aruch & Rema, O.C. 673:1 | Distinct shamash

Excerpts; intervening text omitted

ויניחנו מרחוק קצת משאר נרות מצוה ... הגה: ובמדינות אלו אין נוהגים להוסיף רק מניח אצלן השמש שבו מדליק הנרות והוא עדיף טפי ויש לעשותו יותר ארוך משאר נרות שאם בא להשתמש ישתמש לאותו נר.

One places the additional lamp a little apart from the other mitzvah lamps ... Rema: In these lands, the custom is not to add another lamp, but to place beside them the shamash used for lighting; this is preferable. It should be longer than the other lamps so that, if one uses the light, one uses that lamp.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Read the front-side story alongside Mishlei and Rashi. Which action shows that inspiration continued afterward? Connecting this story to the verse is our learning exercise, not a quotation from Rav Mordechai Eliyahu.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.